

THE SORCERER'S RECKONING

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Book One of The Lattice Chronicles

VERDANTLIFE LLC

The Sorcerer's Reckoning
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First edition.

*For every kid who was told what they would be
before anyone asked who they were.*

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*Little light, little light, burning low,
keep the door for the ones who go.*

— Ashbourne lullaby

PROLOGUE

THE SEAL



THE STORM CAME DOWN off the Greyspine in the second hour after midnight, and Arion Vey knew that he had run out of time.

He stood at the window of the cottage with two fingers resting on the sill, tapping, tapping, a rhythm older than the house. Beyond the glass the Veil had gone the color of pewter. Lightning walked the ridgelines on long white legs. Somewhere down the valley a dog was barking at nothing, the way dogs did when the air was wrong, and the thatch above him hissed with rain.

"They're asleep," Seren said behind him. "Both of them. Finally."

He didn't turn around. If he turned around he would see her face, and if he saw her face he would not do this, and if he did not do this, they would all die. So he watched the lightning and tapped the sill, and said, "Light the lantern, love."

He heard the scrape of the striker, the soft cough of the wick. Gold light found the window and laid his own reflection over the storm: a tired man of middle years, silver at the temples, with a face that people forgot as soon as they looked away from it. He had worked hard at that face. Faces that were forgotten lived longer.

"Arion." Her voice was very steady. Seren's voice was always steadiest when she was most afraid. "Tell me again why it has to be tonight."

"Because they found the Vhessa records." He made himself say it plainly. "Because Kell has a list of every Warden who signed out the Founders' codices in the last ten years, and my name is on it, and by

tomorrow someone at the Spire will start asking why the Warden-Architect spent three months in the eastern march before half of it turned black." He breathed. "Because the thing that came through the breach has learned my scent. And because if any one of them comes looking for me, they will find the boys. And the boys burn brighter than I do."

"They're children."

"They're mine," he said. "That's the whole problem."

He turned then. He couldn't help it.

Seren Harrow stood by the hearth with the lantern in one hand. She was small and fierce and freckled, her hair tied back with a strip of blue cloth, her sleeves still rolled from the washing. There was flour on her cheek. There was always flour on her cheek; he had stopped telling her years ago, because he liked it there. She was looking at him the way she had looked at him the first time, across a market square in Saltreach, as if she could see straight through the forgettable face to the thing underneath and had decided, against all sense, that she liked it.

"Show me," she said.



THE BOYS SLEPT IN the loft, under the eaves, in a nest of quilts that smelled of woodsmoke and lavender. Arion climbed the ladder with the lantern, and Seren came after.

Anthoren was nine, all knees and elbows, sprawled on his back with one arm flung over his eyes. Even asleep he looked like he was in the middle of an argument. He had Seren's freckles and Arion's long hands and a way of staring at things until they gave up their secrets: the clock in the mill, the hinge of a door, the night sky. Last week he had asked his father why stars didn't fall, and when Arion had told him, he'd asked a second question, and a third, and by the seventh Arion had found himself sketching the motion of the heavens on the kitchen table in flour while Seren laughed at them both.

Lexander was four. He slept curled into his brother's side like a puppy, one fist wound tight in Antho's nightshirt. His hair was a riot of dark curls. He had a scab on his knee from falling off the woodpile, and a small iron horseshoe nail clutched in his other hand, which he had found in the road

three days ago and had refused to put down since. "Mine," he'd said, every time anyone reached for it. "Mine. I'm keeping it."

Arion knelt on the boards between them, and for a long moment he only looked.

Then he set the lantern down, and closed his eyes, and *looked* in the other way.

The world fell away. In its place stood the Lattice.

It was everywhere, always. Most people only ever saw the little window of it that belonged to them, a few silver lines of text when they called for it. *Name. Class. Level.* A small, tidy piece of the great machine, polished for their use. But Arion Vey had been born with the blood that saw the whole thing, and the whole thing was vast. It hung over the world like a net of light, threads beyond counting, every thread humming with mana, every knot a life. It ran through the walls of the cottage and the rain outside and the sleeping valley, out across the mountains and the sea, and the ten thousand threads that made a person were laced into it at a thousand points, so that it was impossible to say where the person ended and the Lattice began.

Most people's threads were silver.

His sons' threads were gold.

Not all of them. Not yet. The boys hadn't been Kindled; the Lattice hadn't fully taken hold of them, and wouldn't until each turned sixteen and laid his hand upon a Stone. But the gold was there, under the skin of the world, the way a vein of ore lay under rock. Antho's burned in a slow, dark, deep color, like honey held up to a candle. Lex's was bright and restless and hot, and it flickered at the edges, as if it were already trying to get out.

Root, the gold said, to anyone who knew how to read it. *Here is Root. Here is the blood of the one who made all this.*

Anyone who knew how to read it. The Wardens. The thing in the east.

And the other one. The one Arion did not let himself think about, even here, even now.

"It's so bright," Seren whispered beside him. She didn't have the blood, but she was a Listener, and Listeners could feel what they could not see.

Her hand had found his shoulder. "I can feel it from here. Like standing near a forge."

"Yes."

"Will it hurt them?"

He didn't answer at once. He reached into his coat and drew out the things he had prepared: a silver needle, a small pot of ink ground from the ash of a Founders' cedar, a strip of linen. His hands were perfectly steady. His hands were always steady. It was the rest of him that shook.

"The sealing won't hurt," he said. "They'll sleep through it. It will feel like a dream about being cold."

"And after?"

"After, the Lattice will look at them and see ordinary boys. Common blood. Common classes when they're Kindled. Nothing anyone would hunt." He threaded the needle. "Nothing anyone would *use*."

"And if it breaks?"

That was the question. He had asked it of himself every night for a month.

"It won't break," he said. "Not while I'm alive to hold it."

"Arion."

"It's a good seal, love." He dipped the needle. "It's the best work I've ever done."



HE STARTED WITH ANTHO, because Antho was older and the gold in him was deeper, harder to cover. He drew back the boy's nightshirt and laid his palm flat over his heart, and felt it beating there, quick and fierce.

Seal, he thought, in the language under language, the glyph-speech of the Founders that the scholars called Wellscrip. *Conceal. Let the gold be grey. Let the deep thing sleep.*

The needle moved. It didn't pierce the skin; it touched the threads beneath, the gold ones, and where it touched, Arion's own Authority flowed out of him like blood from a cut. He felt it go, a cold draining, the way warmth leaves a body in snow. The ash-ink hung in the air above the boy's chest, a lattice of fine black lines, and then sank into him and vanished.

Antho stirred. His face creased. He mumbled something.

"Shh," Seren whispered, stroking his hair. "Shh, sweetheart."

Antho's eyes opened a crack. They were unfocused, heavy with sleep. They found his father's face in the lantern light.

"Papa?" he said thickly. "It's cold."

"I know. Go back to sleep."

"Are you doing magic?"

"A little."

Antho considered this with the grave seriousness of the very sleepy. His gaze drifted to his brother, still curled against his side. "Will it hurt him?" he asked.

Arion's hand stopped.

"Only if it breaks," he said quietly. And then, because the boy was still looking at him, because he had always believed in telling his children the truth even when the truth was too large for them: "If it ever breaks, Antho, you look after him. Can you do that? You're his big brother. You look after him."

"Kay," Antho mumbled. His eyes were already closing. "I always do."

The last line of the glyph sank into him. Arion felt the seal settle like a lid onto a pot, and the deep honey-gold of his eldest son dimmed, and dimmed, and went grey.

He let out a breath he hadn't known he was holding. Then he turned to his younger son.



LEX WAS HARDER.

Antho's power had been deep and still. You could lay a lid on still water. Lex's was a fire, and the moment Arion's palm touched his small chest the fire *noticed*. It leapt up toward the needle like a cat after string. The threads under the boy's skin went from gold to white-gold to a color that had no name, and the heat of it came up through Arion's hand so sharply that he hissed.

"Arion?"

"He's fighting it." He set his jaw. "He's four years old and he's fighting it."

"Of course he is." Seren made a sound that was almost a laugh and almost a sob. "He's ours."

Arion bent closer. *Seal*, he thought. *Conceal. Let the gold be grey.* The fire threw the glyph back at him. *Please*, he thought, which was not Wellsript, which was not anything. *Please, little one. Let me hide you. Let me keep you safe.*

The fire flickered. Considered.

And then, in the place under language, something in his son *looked at him*.

It wasn't thought, not yet; Lex was too young for thought of that kind. It was something more basic. The sense of a hand being held out in the dark. *Who are you?*

I'm your father, Arion thought back. *I'm going away for a while. I don't want to. I'm sorry.*

The fire didn't understand the words. But it seemed to understand the sorrow, because slowly, slowly, it let itself be covered.

He worked for a long time. The needle moved and moved. The Authority poured out of him, far more than he had planned for, and the lantern burned lower, and the storm walked off down the valley grumbling to itself. Once Seren had to hold his wrist to keep it steady. Once he had to stop and press the heels of his hands against his eyes until the dizziness passed. The seal on Antho had been a lid. The seal on Lex had to be a forge-door: iron, banded, locked, with the fire still roaring behind it.

And because it had to be locked, it had to have a keeper.

He had known that for a month too. He had not told Seren.

He reached inside himself, past the Authority, past the threads, to the place where *he* was: the shape of his own mind, the knot of memory and habit and love and stubbornness that made Arion Vey into Arion Vey. And he took a piece of it. Not a large piece. A sliver, the width of a fingernail paring. He took his patience and his courtesy and his terrible jokes about smelting, and his memory of the Founders' codes, and the part of him that had once sat up all night with a feverish infant singing nonsense songs about blacksmiths. He took the part of him that was a father.

He pressed it into the seal like a maker's mark into hot iron.

Watch him, he told it. Wake when the seal wakes. Guide him. Tell him what I couldn't.

The sliver didn't answer. It wasn't awake yet. It might never be. But it settled into the lock, gold among the grey, and went still.

When Arion finally sat back on his heels, the threads of his younger son were grey as old pewter, and the only sign of what lay underneath was a faint warmth, like a hearthstone the morning after a fire.

Lex had not woken once. He slept on, fist still tight in his brother's nightshirt, the horseshoe nail still clutched in the other hand.

Arion bent and kissed his forehead. Then Antho's.

"There," he said. His voice came out hoarse. "There. Done."



AT THE BOTTOM OF the ladder, Seren put the lantern on the table and turned to him, and he saw that she had been crying the whole time, silently, the way she did everything difficult.

"How long?" she asked.

"I don't know." He could at least give her that. "Until the breaches are closed. Until the Order forgets my name. Until it's safe."

"That isn't an answer."

"It's the only one I have."

"And what do I tell them?"

He'd thought about this too. "Tell them I was a merchant," he said. "Tell them I went east for trade and didn't come back. Let them be angry with me. It's easier to be angry at a man who left than to grieve a man who's dead, and it's safer than the truth." He swallowed. "Use your name. Harrow. Not Vey. Never Vey. Raise them as Harrows. Let them grow up ordinary."

"They'll never be ordinary."

"Let them think they are. For as long as they can."

She came to him then and put her flour-smudged hand against his cheek and looked at him for a very long time, and he let her, and did not look away.

"You're a fool, Arion Vey," she said at last. "You're the cleverest fool I ever met."

"I know."

"Come back."

"I'll try."

"*Come back*," she said again, fiercely, and kissed him, and then pushed him toward the door before either of them could change their minds.



HE WALKED OUT INTO the wet grey morning. The rain had thinned to a fine mist, and the Veil lay thick along the valley floor, silver-white, softening the hedgerows and the stone walls and the roofs of Ashbourne below. Somewhere a cockerel was making a fool of itself. In the village square, the old Lattice Stone stood in its ring of mossy cobbles, faintly glowing, the way all the Stones glowed at dawn: a crack running through its face, the result of some long-forgotten lightning strike.

He didn't look back at the cottage. He had promised himself he wouldn't. He looked once, which he had not promised himself about, and saw the lantern burning in the window, small and gold against the grey.

A light left on for the lost.

Then he pulled his hood up, and let his face become forgettable, and walked into the mist.

Behind him, deep in the threads of the world, where no one in the valley could see, a line of silver text wrote itself into the great ledger of the Lattice and was filed away among ten thousand million others:

SEAL APPLIED × 2

Subjects: ANTHOREN HARROW (9)

LEXANDER HARROW (4)

Bloodline flag: CONCEALED

Authority expended: 97 / 100

WARDEN-ARCHITECT ARION VEY

Status: CONCEALED

Last known location: —

And beneath it, smaller, in a color that was not silver at all but the deep gold of embers banked for the night, something else. Something the Lattice did not file, because the Lattice did not know it was there.

GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT — DORMANT

Bound to: LEXANDER

Waiting.

Fifteen years would pass before it woke.

PART ONE



THE AWAKENING

CHAPTER 1

THE FORGE AT ASHBOURNE



THE HORSESHOE WAS WRONG, and Lex knew it before the hammer came down.

He knew it the way you know a step is missing in the dark: a tiny lurch of the stomach, a sense of the world being a finger's width off true. The iron on the anvil glowed the color of a ripe apricot, which was right. The tongs were steady, which was right. His arm was already coming down, the hammer a dull grey blur at the end of it, and the angle was right, the weight was right, everything about the blow was exactly, perfectly right.

The iron was wrong.

There was a flaw in it. A seam, deep in the heart of the bar, where some careless smelter in some faraway foundry had let a bubble of slag cool inside. You couldn't see it. You couldn't feel it through the tongs. But Lex could *hear* it, a dull note under the iron's ringing, like a cracked bell under a good one, and he knew with total certainty that if the hammer landed where he'd aimed it, the shoe would split along that seam and fly off the anvil in two pieces.

He turned his wrist. Just slightly. The hammer came down a thumb's width to the left of where he'd aimed it, at a shallower angle, and struck the iron with a bright clean *chang* that went up into the rafters and set the hanging chains trembling.

The shoe held.

Lex let out a breath. He struck again, and again, rolling the iron over in the tongs, working the curve around the anvil's horn, and the flaw stayed

buried and quiet in the heart of the metal where he'd coaxed it. When the shoe was shaped, he lifted it in the tongs and plunged it into the slack tub, and the water screamed and boiled and threw up a column of steam that smelled of rust and rain.

A small silver box opened in the corner of his vision.

SKILL PROGRESS

Smithing – Journeyman 3 (81%)

He dismissed it with a thought. Eighty-one percent. It had been eighty-one percent for nine days. It would be eighty-one percent tomorrow, and the day after, and on some bright morning a month from now it would tick over to eighty-two, and that would be a good day, and he would tell no one, because no one would care.

"You did the thing again," said a voice from the doorway.

Lex didn't turn around. "What thing?"

"The thing where you stop in the middle of a swing and stare at the iron like it insulted your mother." Brannoc Holt ducked under the lintel, which he had to do, because Brannoc Holt was the largest man in the southern Vale and possibly the largest man in Caldor. He was bald as an egg and bearded like a thundercloud, and the beard was mostly soot. He carried a basket of eggs under one arm, which made him look like a bear that had robbed a henhouse. "And then you move your wrist a hair, and the shoe comes out perfect, and you look like you want to throw up."

"I don't look like I want to throw up."

"You look like a man who's just walked across a frozen pond and heard it crack." Brannoc set the eggs down on the workbench, nudging aside a pair of tongs and a cat. The cat, a scrawny grey tom named Slag, gave him a look of profound betrayal and moved six inches to the left. "It's the slag pockets again, isn't it? You hear them."

Lex fished the shoe out of the tub and turned it over. Clean. Even. A good shoe. You'd never know there was a flaw buried in it. "It's nothing."

"It's not nothing. I've been smithing forty years, lad. I've never once heard a slag pocket."

"Maybe you're deaf."

"Maybe I am. Maybe I'm also twice your weight and could put you through that wall." Brannoc said this with great affection. He picked an egg out of the basket, examined it, and cracked it on the edge of the anvil. "Breakfast?"

"Don't cook eggs on the anvil."

"I always cook eggs on the anvil."

"It's disgusting."

"It's *efficient*." Brannoc slid the egg onto the flat of a shovel and held it over the coals, where it began to sizzle at once. "Your father would have liked that. Efficient."

Lex went very still.

"Sorry," Brannoc said after a moment. He didn't look up from the egg. "That slipped out."

"You never met my father."

"No. Your mother talked about him, though. When she brought you round to watch the forge. Said he never wasted a motion." Brannoc turned the egg with a flick of his wrist. "Said you'd got that from him."

"Did she say I got the *leaving* from him too?"

That came out harder than he'd meant it to. Brannoc looked up from the shovel, and for a moment the big man's face was very gentle, and Lex had to look away from it, out the open door of the forge, at the green.



ASHBOURNE WOKE SLOWLY, THE way villages did in the Vale, when the Veil lay thick in the hollows and the sun had to fight its way down off the mountains. Mist curled over the cobbles of the village green. It hung in silver skeins between the chestnut trees and drifted in the doorway of the Crooked Kettle, where Mother Orla was beating a rug against the wall with a violence that suggested the rug had done something unforgivable. Up the lane, the mill wheel was turning with a slow wooden groan. Somebody's goat was standing on somebody's roof again. Two of the Dunstan children were throwing pebbles at it.

And in the middle of the green, as it had stood for longer than anyone could remember, was the Lattice Stone.

It wasn't impressive, as Stones went. Lex had heard that the ones in Highcrest were twelve feet tall and carved with the faces of the Founders, and that the Great Stone in the Spire was taller than a church and glowed like moonlight even at noon. Ashbourne's Stone came up to his chest. It was grey and lichened and roughly the shape of a gravestone, and a great crack ran down its face from top to bottom, where lightning had struck it some time in his grandmother's grandmother's day. In the early morning it gave off a faint silver shimmer, like a fish's belly seen through water, and the mist always lay a little thicker around it, as if drawn there.

Three years ago, on the morning of his sixteenth birthday, he had walked up to that Stone with half the village watching and put his hand flat on its cracked, cold face.

He remembered it perfectly. He remembered all of it. That was the worst part.

He remembered the way his heart had been going, so hard he'd been afraid people could see it through his shirt. He remembered Brannoc behind him, enormous and silent, and Mother Orla dabbing at her eyes with her apron, and old Reeve Dunstan intoning the words of the Kindling in his reedy voice: *Let the Lattice see you. Let it know your worth. Let it name you as you are.* He remembered thinking, absurdly, that he hoped it would be something with a sword in it. A [Squire]. A [Guardsmen]. Something that would let him leave.

He remembered the cold. The Stone had been cold under his palm, colder than stone should be, and then the cold had gone *into* him, up his arm and into his chest and down to the soles of his feet, and for one strange instant he'd felt as if something deep inside him was knocking on a door.

And then the door hadn't opened, and the cold had gone, and the silver words had unfolded in front of his eyes for the very first time.

KINDLING COMPLETE

Welcome to the Lattice, LEX HARROW.

Class assigned: SMITH

Grade: Common

Level cap: 24

Common.

He'd stood there with his hand on the Stone and read it four times. Then he'd taken his hand away, and turned around, and said, "Smith," and everyone had clapped, and Brannoc had clapped him on the shoulder so hard it left a bruise, and Mother Orla had said, "Oh, *lovely*, Lex, that's lovely, you'll be ever so useful," and he'd smiled and smiled until his face hurt.

He'd been a smith's apprentice since he was eleven. He'd spent five years at Brannoc's anvil. Of course the Lattice made him a Smith. What else would it see when it looked at him? It looked at a boy who hammered iron, and it said: *Here is a boy who hammers iron. Let him hammer iron forever.*

Level cap: 24.

That was the part that people didn't talk about. Everyone knew it; nobody said it. Common classes stopped at twenty-four. You could work your whole life, you could be the best smith in the kingdom, and when you hit twenty-four the silver numbers simply stopped. You could hone your skills, a little. You could grow wiser and older and better at what you did. But the Lattice had decided your shape, and there was no growing out of it.

Born to the Ceiling, they called it, in the taverns, when they'd had enough ale to say it. *Born to the Ceiling and buried under it.*

Brannoc had been level twenty-four for nineteen years.



"STATUS," LEX MUTTERED, UNDER his breath, half out of habit and half out of a kind of morbid curiosity, the way you prod a sore tooth with your tongue.

The silver panel slid open in front of his eyes.

LEX HARROW

Age: 19

Class: Smith (Common)

Level: 9 Cap: 24

XP: 62%

MIG 16 AGI 9 VIT 14

INT 13 SPI 4 RES 15

Health 140/140

Mana 40/40

Stamina 150/150

SKILLS

Smithing Journeyman 3

Hammer Use Apprentice 6

Heat Sense Apprentice 2

Endurance Apprentice 4

He looked at it the way he looked at it every morning, without expectation.

Level nine. Three years after his Kindling, he was level nine, which was slow but not shameful; most smiths didn't reach double figures until their twenties. His Might was good, and his Vitality, and his Resolve was better than it had any right to be, which Brannoc said was because he was stubborn as a mule with a grudge. His Intellect was respectable. His Agility was the agility of a young man who stood in one place hitting things all day.

And his Spirit was four.

Four. The lowest score he'd ever heard of, for anyone, of any class. Old Mag the herbwoman, who was ninety and blind in one eye, had a Spirit of eleven. The Dunstan twins had Spirits of nine apiece. Spirit was the stat for mana, for sensitivity to magic, for the inner light that let a person touch the Veil and make it do things; most people didn't need much of it, but everybody had *some*, the way everybody had some blood. Lex had four. It was as if he'd been born with a hole in him where his magic should have been.

You're just practical, Mother Orla had told him once, kindly. *Some folk are dreamers and some are doers.*

He wondered sometimes, staring at that number, why it bothered him so much. What would he even have done with more Spirit? Smiths didn't need mana. Smiths needed strong arms and good eyes and patience. He had all three.

But every time he looked at that four, he felt the strangest thing. Not shame, exactly. Something more like the sense of a word on the tip of his tongue. A door in a familiar house that he walked past every day and had never once tried to open.

He closed the panel.

"Egg," said Brannoc, holding out the shovel.

Lex took the egg, which was perfectly cooked, and ate it with his fingers, and burned his tongue, and didn't complain.



THEY WORKED THROUGH THE morning.

There were shoes to finish for the Dunstans' plough horses, and a cracked kettle to braze for Mother Orla, and a set of hinges for the chapel door, which had been squealing so loudly during last week's lantern service that Sister Agathe had stopped in the middle of a prayer to glare at it. There was a new ploughshare to start for Farmer Tobbin, who had broken his old one on a rock and was taking it very personally. The forge filled with the familiar music of the work: the roar of the bellows, the hiss of the slack tub, the tap and ring and clang of iron. Slag the cat slept on the warm brick ledge beside the hearth with his paws tucked under him. Brannoc hummed hymns, badly, and occasionally broke off to tell Lex he was holding his tongs like a man holding a dead fish.

Lex didn't mind. He liked the work. He had always liked the work; that was the joke of it. If the Lattice had given him any class in the world, he would have chosen to spend his days at an anvil anyway. He loved the way iron changed in the fire, the way it went from black to red to orange to gold, softening as it heated, until it would take any shape you were patient enough to give it. He loved the weight of a good hammer. He loved the smell of hot metal and coal smoke and the way his whole body sang when he got a hard piece right.

He just wished it had been his choice.

Around midday, Pell came by.

Pell was the miller's youngest, fifteen and gangly, with a shock of straw-colored hair and a face like an eager spaniel's. He had decided some time ago that Lex was the most interesting person in Ashbourne, which said more about Ashbourne than about Lex, and he came by the forge most days on one invented errand or another.

"Da wants to know if you've fixed the gear-pin," he said, hovering in the doorway.

"I fixed the gear-pin yesterday," said Lex. "I gave it to your da yesterday. He paid me for it yesterday."

"Oh." Pell considered this. "He must've forgot."

"Must have."

Pell sidled into the forge and perched on an upturned bucket, well clear of the hearth. Brannoc, who knew perfectly well why Pell came by and thought it was funny, gave the boy a nod and went out the back to fetch more coal.

"My Kindling's in nine days," Pell said.

"I know," Lex said. "You've told me. Every day. For a month."

"Do you think I'll get something good?"

Lex set down the hinge he'd been filing and looked at the boy. Pell's face was so hopeful it hurt. "What do you want to get?"

"Ranger," Pell said at once. "Or Scout. Or—" He went pink. "Or Knight. I know you can't get Knight from a village Stone, everyone says it only happens to nobles, but Gaffer Wim says his cousin's boy got [Squire] down in Lowmarsh and he's in the King's Guard now and he has a *horse*."

"Gaffer Wim's cousin's boy," said Lex, "is a liar, and so is Gaffer Wim."

"You don't know that."

"I've met Gaffer Wim."

Pell scuffed his boot against the bucket. "Well, I want *something*. Not Miller. I don't want to be a Miller." He hesitated. "Did you know? Before your Kindling? Did you know you'd get Smith?"

"I hoped I wouldn't," Lex said, before he could stop himself.

Pell's eyes went wide.

"Not because there's anything wrong with being a smith," Lex said quickly. "It's good work. Honest work. Brannoc's the best man I know,

and he's a smith." He picked the hinge back up, mostly so he'd have something to do with his hands. "I just... wanted to see what else there was. Before the Stone told me."

"Because of your da?" Pell asked. "Everyone says he was a traveller. Before he went off. Ma says he came from Saltreach, or maybe further."

"Everyone says a lot of things."

"And your brother—"

"Pell."

The boy shut his mouth with a click.

Lex filed the hinge. The rasp went *shhk, shhk, shhk* in the quiet. Out on the green, the goat had come down off the roof and was eating the Dunstans' washing. Somewhere a woman was shouting at it.

"Sorry," Pell said, very small.

"It's fine."

"It's just, people are saying things again. About the mountains."

Lex didn't look up. "People always say things about the mountains."

"Not like this." Pell leaned forward on his bucket, lowering his voice, though there was no one to overhear but the cat. "Tobbin's brother came down from Thistledown yesterday. He says the traders up there won't go past the second ridge anymore. He says there's lights in the Hollowmaw. Green lights, and black ones, and sometimes at night you can hear something howling. Not wolves. Something *worse*." Pell swallowed. "He says the mad warlock's woken up properly. He says he's been killing Wardens. Whole patrols of them. They go up and they don't come down."

The file stopped.

"He also says," Pell went on, oblivious, "that it's not just the warlock. He says there's something in the mist up there. Something black. It comes down the gullies at night, like smoke, only it moves *against* the wind, and wherever it's been, the grass goes grey and the birds stop singing. He says it took one of the Tanner boys' sheep. Not killed it. *Took* it. They found it the next morning standing in the middle of the field with its eyes all white, and it didn't eat, and it didn't move, and when they tried to lead it home it just stood there. Breathing. Like it was waiting for something."

Lex set the file down. Very carefully.

"Who told you all this?"

"Tobbin's brother. At the Kettle. Last night." Pell looked at him uncertainly. "Do you think it's true? Do you think it's your br—do you think it's the warlock doing it?"

The forge was very quiet. The fire muttered to itself in the hearth.

"I think," said Lex, "that Tobbin's brother drinks more than Tobbin, and Tobbin drinks more than anyone."

"Oh," said Pell, deflated.

"Go home, Pell. Tell your da I fixed the gear-pin."

The boy went. Lex stood at the anvil with his hands flat on the cool iron for a long time after, staring at nothing.



HE HAD BEEN ELEVEN years old the night the cottage burned.

He did not, as a rule, let himself remember it. He had gotten very good at not remembering it, the way you get good at walking around a hole in the floor. But Pell's voice had kicked something loose, and now it came up whether he wanted it or not.

He remembered the smell first. Smoke, and something under the smoke, sharp and strange, like a lightning strike in a closed room. He remembered waking in the loft with his eyes stinging and the air full of a terrible orange light, and Antho's side of their bed empty and cold.

Antho had been sixteen. That was the day of his Kindling. Lex remembered that much: the morning, the whole village on the green, Antho walking up to the cracked Stone with his chin high and his long hands shoved in his pockets so nobody would see them shaking. Antho had been strange for weeks before. Quiet. Not sleeping. Lex had heard him get up in the night and go out to sit on the woodpile under the stars, and once he'd heard him talking, low and urgent, to someone who wasn't there.

Antho had put his hand on the Stone, and the Stone had screamed.

Lex didn't know how else to describe it. It hadn't made a sound you could hear with your ears. But every person on the green had flinched at once, and every dog in the village had started to howl, and the silver shimmer of the Stone had gone, for one instant, black. Then Antho had pulled his hand away and stood there, swaying, staring at nothing, at something only he could see, and his face had gone the color of old ash.

He hadn't told anyone what class he'd gotten. He'd walked home without a word and gone up to the loft and lain on the bed with his face to the wall. When Mother tried to talk to him, he didn't answer. When Lex tried, Antho had said, without turning round, in a voice Lex had never heard before: *Go away, Lex. Please. Go away. It's so loud.*

And that night, the cottage had burned.

Lex remembered climbing down the ladder through smoke so thick he couldn't see his own hands. He remembered the heat. He remembered the main room of the cottage, their kitchen, their hearth, the table where Mother made bread, and the shapes moving in it through the smoke. He remembered his mother's voice, calling his brother's name, over and over, *Antho, Antho, sweetheart, look at me, look at me*, and his brother's voice answering in words that weren't words, a sound like wind going through a crack in a wall.

He remembered Antho's eyes. When his brother had turned and looked at him through the smoke, Antho's eyes had been black. Not dark. Black. Black from edge to edge, like holes cut in the world.

Then something had happened that Lex had never been able to remember clearly. A darkness that was darker than the smoke. A cold that came through the heat. A sound like a door slamming somewhere very far away.

And then he was outside, coughing on his hands and knees in the wet grass of the yard, and Brannoc's huge arms were around him, and the whole cottage was a pillar of fire, and his mother was gone, and his brother was gone, and the village was screaming.

They never found her body. They never found anything. The fire had burned so hot that it melted the iron pots on the hearth.

Antho was seen once more, three days later. A shepherd saw him walking up into the Greyspine, barefoot in the snow, alone. He didn't answer when the shepherd called to him. He didn't look back.

Murderer, the village said, once they'd stopped saying *poor boy. Murderer. He went mad at his Kindling and burned his own mother alive. You could see it in his eyes.*

And Lex, who was eleven, and had seen his brother's eyes, believed them.

Brannoc took him in. Brannoc gave him a cot in the loft above the forge and a hammer and a reason to get up in the morning, and never once asked him what he'd seen. Lex had worked at the anvil every day since, and had gotten very, very good at not remembering.

And now people were saying that the mad warlock of the Hollowmaw was killing Wardens in the mountains.

He found that his hands were shaking. He pressed them flat against the anvil until they stopped.



THE AFTERNOON WORE ON. The sun came down off the Greyspine and made a brief gold appearance over the valley before the clouds took it back. Brannoc came in with the coal and saw Lex's face and didn't say anything, only clapped him on the shoulder and put him to work on Farmer Tobbin's ploughshare, which was a long, hard, heavy job that didn't leave room for thinking.

Lex was grateful. He worked until his arms ached and his shirt was soaked through and the air in the forge shimmered with heat. He worked until the thoughts went away and there was nothing in his head but the iron.

That was when he started to notice the other thing.

He noticed it first in the iron itself. He was drawing out the edge of the ploughshare, the hammer rising and falling in its steady rhythm, *chang, chang, chang*, and somewhere around the fortieth blow, the iron started to *hum*.

Not ring. Hum. A low, almost subsonic vibration that he felt through the tongs and the hammer haft and the soles of his feet, a sound that seemed to come from inside the metal and inside himself at the same time. The glow of the iron seemed to deepen. Where his hammer struck, tiny motes of light lifted off the surface like sparks, but they didn't fall. They hung in the air for a heartbeat, gold, and then winked out.

He stopped hammering. The hum stopped.

He stared at the iron. It was just iron. Orange and cooling and ordinary.

"Brannoc," he said slowly. "Did you see that?"

Brannoc was at the bellows. "See what?"

"The sparks. They were... they didn't fall."

Brannoc looked at the ploughshare, then at Lex, then at the ploughshare again. "Lad, you've been at that for three hours without a drink. Go put your head in the rain barrel."

Lex went and put his head in the rain barrel. The water was cold enough to make his teeth ache. When he came back, the ploughshare was cooling on the anvil, black and ordinary, and the forge was the forge.

But it kept happening.

Not with the iron. With everything. Small things. As the afternoon darkened toward evening, he began to notice that the fire in the hearth leaned toward him when he passed, the flames bending in his direction like flowers toward a window. He picked up a cold bar of iron from the rack and it was warm in his hand, warm all the way through, as if it had been sitting in the sun. When he reached for the slack tub, the water in it rippled, very slightly, before his fingers touched it.

And when he looked out the door of the forge at the village green, at the old cracked Lattice Stone in its ring of cobbles, he saw that the silver shimmer that always hung around it had changed color.

It was gold.

Just at the edges. Just a faint, warm gold, like the light of a lantern seen through fog, flickering at the edges of the silver. And it was leaning toward the forge. Toward *him*.

He blinked, and it was silver again.

"Brannoc," he said, and his voice came out strange. "I think something's wrong with me."



HE DIDN'T SAY IT loud enough. Brannoc had gone into the house to start supper, and the forge was empty except for Lex and the cat.

Slag was sitting bolt upright on the warm brick ledge, every hair on his scrawny body standing on end, staring at the open door.

Outside, the evening had come down blue and cold. The mist was rising off the green in long pale streamers, thicker than Lex had seen it in weeks. The chestnut trees dripped. Lamplight glowed in the windows of

the Crooked Kettle, and somewhere up the lane a mother was calling her children in for supper. Ordinary sounds. An ordinary evening.

Except that the mist was moving the wrong way.

Lex walked to the door and stood in it, looking out. The breeze was coming down off the mountains, from the north, cold and smelling of snow. And the mist on the green, the thick silver mist of the Veil, was drifting *north*. Into the wind. Toward the mountains. Slowly, steadily, like water draining out of a basin, as if something up there in the dark of the Greyspine had taken a long, deep breath and was pulling it in.

And under the mist, low in the gullies on the far side of the valley, so faint he might have imagined it, there was something else. A darker color. A smudge, like a thumbprint of soot on a window.

Lex stared at it until his eyes watered.

That was when he heard the footsteps.

They came up the lane from the south road, slow and deliberate. Boots on cobbles. A walking stick, tapping. Lex turned his head and saw a figure resolving out of the mist: a tall man, thin, in a long grey traveling cloak that hung to the tops of his boots and was dark with damp at the hem. A hood shadowed his face. He leaned on a staff of pale wood, and when he walked, small things sewn into the cloak caught the lamplight and glittered: tiny charms of brass, dozens of them, each one shaped like a lightning bolt.

On the stranger's shoulder sat a raven, black as a hole in the evening.

The stranger didn't stop at the Crooked Kettle, where any traveler would stop. He didn't stop at the Reeve's house, or the chapel. He walked straight across the green, past the Lattice Stone, without once looking at it, and came to a halt at the edge of the forge light, where the orange glow of the hearth spilled out across the wet cobbles and turned the mist to gold.

He pushed back his hood.

He was older than Lex had thought. Sixty, perhaps, or a hard-lived fifty. His face was long and lined and weathered brown, his beard close-cropped and grey, his hair grey and swept back from a high forehead. A scar ran from his left temple down into his beard, pale and jagged, like the track of a lightning strike. His eyes were very bright and very sharp and the color of a storm cloud, and they looked at Lex, at *all* of Lex, in a way that made Lex feel as if the man were reading him like a page.

The raven on his shoulder ruffled its feathers and said, in a perfectly clear voice, "*Found him.*"

"So we have, Quill," said the stranger softly. "So we have."

He looked at the forge. At the anvil, the slack tub, the cooling ploughshare. At the hearth, where the fire had risen in the last few moments to a roar, every flame bent toward the doorway where Lex stood. Then he looked back at Lex, and something in that sharp, weathered face softened, and something else in it tightened, as if he were looking at a ghost.

"You have his hands," the stranger said. "I'd know them anywhere."

Lex found his voice. "Whose hands?"

The stranger didn't answer at once. The mist eddied around his boots. Behind him, across the green, the old Lattice Stone pulsed once, faintly, gold.

"Young man," he said at last, very quietly, "I've come a long way to find you. And I'm afraid I've come almost too late." He leaned on his staff. The brass charms on his cloak chimed softly, like distant bells. "Your destiny is waiting for you, Lex Harrow. And it is not at this anvil."

THE STORY CONTINUES



Book Two of The Lattice Chronicles

The Sorcerer's Legacy